

Improved entertainment

Last Diwali, I was trying very hard to convince myself that it was worth it to shell out many thousands to buy a large-screen HDTV for the living room. I just had to visit an ecommerce web site or a large-format electronic store for the festive buying rush: lucrative deals aplenty, there was no dearth of brands fighting tooth-and-nail for your attention, and budget wasn't a problem. However, value for money was. I didn't buy an HDTV. Something other than the task of convincing my better half to rearrange the furniture held me back.

Low-end or high-end, smart or not, HDTVs are useless if you don't have quality HD content to view on them. Blu-ray discs are still too expensive and even though DTH operators have started adding HD channels into their repertoire, these are few and far between. Videocon's DTH service has the most HD channels compared to its competitors. How many HD channels? Just 22 (broadcasts in 1080i, not the superior 1080p), and they are all pretty expensive if you were to subscribe to them all. So not only do we have to be content with the limited pool of channels, whatever little is offered is charged at premium rates. A double whammy.

For the discerning customer who needs choices, cable digitisation couldn't come soon enough. I have no doubt that cable digitisation will proliferate beyond the metros this year, championing the cause of digital entertainment. Once people start seeing the difference between standard and high-definition content, it's only a matter of time before their demand for an improved entertainment experience rises. Cable digitisation alone won't contribute to a spike in HDTV sales though, not if they can't strike deals with broadcasters and content providers.

Cable digitisation offers benefits to everyone – the government, broadcasters, cable operators get increased revenue and the users get improved services, including HD content, high-speed broadband internet, video-on-demand and interactive television services. All of this, I hope, will finally become a reality this year – and not just in metros. And as the cable operators go on the offensive with the government's digitisation mandate, DTH operators will be hard-pressed to ramp up their services as well, and they will. Most

popular DTH operators in the country are controlled and operated by large telcos such as Airtel, Reliance, Tata, and Videocon, among others, and so is much of the bandwidth in the nation – and they have plenty of it. Although a resurgence of IPTV seems unlikely, innovative entertainment avenues may transpire – one can hope, at least. And this may really push the envelop of improved entertainment to a new level, at least to early-adopters and premium users.

Just think about it for a second. Selective bandwidth boosting techniques by ISPs (re: telcos) can further enhance the HD streaming experience this year – just like YouTube videos enjoy faster speeds than other web sites on some select Indian ISPs. If FDI has its way, and if foreign online entities are allowed to engage in online business in India later this year (and that's a big IF), it's hard not to imagine Hulu and Netflix offering their services soon enough. I know, that may be asking



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for too much in one year, but I'm hopeful, and it's about time anyway.

TRAI (Telecom Regulatory Authority of India), the government body responsible to enforce digitisation in India, expects the nation to switch to digital entertainment by 2014. Seeing how that's now just one year away, I expect at least 30 to 50 per cent of cable digitisation to roll out by the end of this year. And if every stakeholder works towards meeting that deadline, an improved entertainment experience won't be a luxury that only a few can afford, but the norm.

I'm hopeful that this will all sort itself out over the course of this year, and come Diwali, make it a no-brainer for me to buy an expensive HDTV, quite simply because it will be indisputable value for money for offering a much-improved entertainment experience. **d**